Structural Blind Spots of Window-Based Trust Aggregation in Low-Altitude UAV Networks

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Abstract: Trust scores are useful in a cooperative UAV mission only when they inform an operational decision. This paper studies that link at the trust-stream level. We construct five normalized evidence streams—behavior, communication, energy, task execution, and history—and train a supervised encoder to estimate node risk, then ask what a trust aggregator has to represent in order to catch intermittent attackers. The executable artifact is deliberately narrower than a full multi-agent reinforcement-learning system: it uses simulator labels during offline training, freezes the model for evaluation, and does not learn from environment rewards or deployment trajectories. On 50 held-out generated seeds with 15 UAVs and a 30% malicious-node ratio, the model obtains 97.1% accuracy and a 95.7% F-score against 97.5% and 96.2% for a same-feature MLP, a difference that is statistically insignificant on paired seeds and changes sign between training runs. The aggregate metric is saturated at this difficulty, so the representation question is answered in a regime where it still discriminates: with a logistic probe on the same features, adding five scale-free temporal-shape statistics raises accuracy from 91.6% to 95.3% and lifts on–off detection from 62.6% to 93.2%. The marginal window summaries that conventional trust aggregation computes are informationally blind to periodic on–off behaviour, and the two blocks prove complementary rather than redundant: the marginal block detects 93.2% of constant attackers but only 62.6% of on–off ones, while the shape block alone inverts that pattern, reaching 93.2% on–off and 17.0% on constant. Permuting each series along the time axis preserves every marginal quantity and collapses the shape block's on–off recall from 93.2% to 6.1%, so the signal is sequence order rather than added dimensionality. A paired duty-cycle sweep shows the consequence: as the attacker's active fraction falls from 50% to 5%, GDM-DTM's on–off detection collapses from 42.7% to 0.0%, while the shape-block methods degrade gracefully from 92.7% to 12.0%. S-TIM exceeds that baseline by +9.0 pp accuracy and +15.0 pp F-score on paired seeds ($p < 10^{-6}$), though that comparison is against our own reimplementation of GDM-DTM. The auxiliary heads carried by the released encoder contribute nothing measurable, and we do not claim them. The results establish reproducibility and feasibility only within the generated trust-stream setting. They do not transfer to packet data: on the bundled 49-step ns-3-derived trace the proposed model detects none of five malicious nodes, which we report as an external-validity failure. Claims about online adaptation, communication cost, and flight deployment likewise require independent experiments.

Keywords: UAV networks; trust management; task allocation; zero trust; reproducible simulation

1 Introduction

UAV swarms used for inspection, sensing, and emergency response rely on nodes that remain inside the mission after admission. A valid identity is therefore not sufficient evidence of trustworthy behavior. A compromised node can selectively forward traffic, falsify a task result, or alternate between benign and harmful behavior while retaining the privileges granted by its earlier history. Dynamic topology and intermittent links make those behaviors difficult to distinguish from ordinary failures [1, 2].

Trust management addresses this problem by updating a node score from recent observations. Existing schemes use fuzzy fusion, anomaly profiles, provenance, or group decisions [7, 8, 10, 23]. Their scores, however, are often evaluated only as detector outputs. In a mission, the practical question is what changes after a node becomes risky: whether it may receive a sensitive task, how much traffic it may relay, and when it should be isolated. This study examines that narrower trust-to-allocation question.

We present S-TIM (Shape-augmented Trust Inference Model) as a reproducible proof of concept rather than a deployment-ready zero-trust architecture. The artifact generates five trust-factor streams, fits a supervised encoder, and uses its risk output in a model-based task-allocation simulation. Although the

architecture was motivated by parameterized multi-agent decision making, the released training procedure is not reinforcement learning: there is no sampled return, Bellman target, policy-gradient update, or online interaction with an environment. Calling the executable model MARL would therefore overstate what was implemented.

The study asks two bounded questions. First, how should generated trust streams be summarised so that constant, dormant, and on–off attackers are all separable on held-out random seeds? Second, under the allocation rules encoded in the same simulator, does trust-guided selection improve a task-success proxy? The answer to the first question is that the summarisation step, not the classifier, is the binding constraint: the marginal window aggregates that conventional trust aggregation uses leave periodic on–off attackers at 20–38% detection, and five scale-free shape statistics lift that to 90–92%. A paired duty-cycle sweep then shows how far this goes—below a 20% active fraction the rule-based aggregator is functionally blind, identifying none of 150 pooled on–off nodes at a 5% duty, while shape-aware methods still recover a seventh of them. The answer to the second is suggestive rather than causal because the task simulator contains mechanism-specific rules. A short ns-3-derived trace is included to expose, rather than hide, the remaining packet-level gap.

Problem statement. This paper addresses a trust-layer decision problem for fixed identities: how should a risk estimate derived from noisy multi-factor evidence affect a subsequent task-allocation decision? The empirical scope is a generated trust-stream benchmark. It does not cover admission control, Sybil resistance, real-time distributed execution, or flight deployment.

Figure 1 gives the intended deployment architecture. Only its trust-stream classifier and allocation proxy are exercised in the released artifact. The contributions are consequently limited to the following:

- a documented generator for behavioral, communication, energy, task, and historical trust streams under three temporal attack patterns;
- a characterisation of a structural blind spot in window-based trust aggregation, with a five-dimensional shape block that closes it, a time-shuffle control that separates the gain from added dimensionality, replication of the gain across three structurally different learners, and a paired duty-cycle sweep showing that the scalar-aggregation family reaches *zero* on–off detection at a 5% duty while the shape-block methods retain 12.0%;
- a reproducible supervised encoder and same-feature LR/MLP comparators evaluated on disjoint training and evaluation seeds;
- three explicit negative results on the architecture itself: enlarging the training set sixfold, replacing the degenerate auxiliary targets with attack-modality supervision, and sweeping the decision threshold all leave S-TIM statistically indistinguishable from a single-head MLP on the same features. The gain over rule-based fusion comes from the representation, not the network.

The remainder of this paper reviews related work, defines the intended architecture and executable subset, reports the trust-stream experiments and packet-trace check, and closes with limitations.

2 Related Work

Trust evaluation for UAV networks now includes reputation models, evidence fusion, blockchain support, and learning-based designs. Yet low-altitude UAV studies rarely integrate zero-trust verification, distributed trust learning, uncertainty aggregation, and mission incentives. We review three related areas: UAV trust management, zero-trust assessment, and MARL for UAV networking and security.

2.1 Trust Management in UAV and FANET Systems

Recent surveys show that trust management has become a core security primitive in FANETs, where dynamic topology, intermittent links, and resource limits make purely identity-based protection insufficient [1–5]. Existing schemes fall into three categories: behavior-centric trust analytics, distributed or blockchain-supported trust, and learning-enhanced trust evaluation.

Behavior-centric trust evaluation widely uses fuzzy and evidence-fusion methods to combine heterogeneous observations. Benfriha et al. proposed FUBA, which uses fuzzy logic to integrate indicators

such as RSSI, packet delivery ratio, delay, battery level, and humidity to identify insider threats in FANETs [8]. Li et al. developed an adaptive multi-granularity trust management scheme for UAV visual sensor security under adversarial attacks, where coarse- and fine-grained evidence is fused to improve robustness against known and unknown threats [9]. Akram et al. introduced GALTrust, which combines generative adversarial learning with type-2 fuzzy logic to improve adaptability to emerging malicious behaviors in spatial crowdsourcing drone services [10]. More recent federated-security studies also move trust assessment toward collaborative anomaly detection, including FL-based intrusion detection for FANETs, multimodal swarm anomaly detection, and communication-efficient FL for resource-constrained UAV-IoT systems [11–13]. Moving to task offloading, Kumar et al. evaluate trust for UAV-as-a-Service by combining residual energy, achievable data rate, and a reputation score that is transferred between a task and a service UAV through a Rubinstein bargaining game [24]. Their trust value is an energy gate multiplied by a weighted reputation and rate term, so it expresses resource adequacy and prior success rather than adversarial intent, and the paper reports a small improvement in delay, energy, and failure rate with no adversary in the loop. These studies significantly enrich trust evidence modeling. Their remaining limitation for the problem considered here is not that they cannot detect insider behavior at all, but that fuzzy, profile-based, or task-specific fusion can become sensitive to distribution shifts when the malicious population is dense and attack timing is deliberately evasive.

A second line of work improves trust persistence and auditability through distributed storage or hierarchical trust exchange. Ge et al. developed a provenance-aware distributed trust model for resilient UAV networks, highlighting the value of peer-to-peer evidence tracing in hostile environments [7]. Zuo et al. proposed a hierarchical blockchain-based trust measurement method for drone clusters to address trust inheritance, cross-cluster re-evaluation, and historical trust verification under dynamic node entry and exit [6]. Akram et al. proposed TMIoDT, which integrates digital twins, blockchain, and deep-learning-based intrusion detection to secure Open RAN-based Internet of Drone Things applications [17]. Closely related secure-FL frameworks have further explored malicious-node detection and trusted collaboration through blockchain-supported service provisioning, privacy-preserving IoDT security, and hierarchical federated aggregation [18–21]. Xu et al. pair a Bayesian trust assessment for quantum federated learning with Stackelberg incentives for the same UAV-assisted setting [22]. The two parts are separable: the incentive side is a full game-theoretic construction, whereas the trust degree itself is the posterior mean of a Beta–Binomial model, that is, a smoothed cumulative proportion of high-quality model updates. Their reported neutral device, which alternates between good and bad updates, therefore settles at an intermediate trust value rather than converging to a malicious verdict—an outcome the aggregator implies by construction rather than by choice. More recently, Hu et al. proposed GDM-DTM for malicious-node detection in low-altitude UAV networks by combining group decision making with dynamic trust management [23]. These schemes improve distributed credibility, trust persistence, and malicious-node detection. For our setting, the central gap is that the trust state is usually treated as an assessment output rather than as the basis for learned reward, penalty, and task-allocation decisions.

2.2 Zero-Trust and Continuous Trust Assessment

Zero trust shifts security from perimeter-based assumptions to continuous, resource-centric verification. The NIST zero-trust architecture defines this paradigm through the principle of "never trust, always verify" and replaces implicit perimeter-based trust with continuous, context-aware verification [15]. Building on this idea, Wang et al. proposed a zero-trust-driven collaborative intrusion detection framework for IoT that uses continuous trust assessment to support distributed security decisions [26]. In the UAV and 6G context, Al Ridhawi and Aloqaily integrated zero trust, digital twins, federated learning, and blockchain into a UAV-enabled 6G framework, highlighting the broader relevance of decentralized trust enforcement in highly dynamic aerial networks [27]. In the UAV authentication domain, Wang et al. introduced a context-aware trust evaluation model for malicious UAV detection during authentication, showing that trust can also be injected into the authentication stage rather than being treated purely as a post hoc reputation signal [14].

Zero trust is particularly relevant to low-altitude UAV swarms: node roles may change during flight, links may appear and disappear rapidly, and local observations may be incomplete or noisy. Trust decisions cannot be based solely on prior membership or static credentials, but must be continuously updated from current observations, device status, communication behavior, and mission context. Therefore, trust decisions should be dynamic, uncertainty-aware, and resource-conscious rather than static or binary.

These studies move trust evaluation closer to continuous verification. Nevertheless, the current

zero-trust literature still focuses mainly on authentication, access control, or intrusion detection. It does not fully address how trust should evolve online in low-altitude UAV swarms when heterogeneous evidence from behavior, communication quality, task execution, energy state, and historical interactions must be fused under strict resource constraints. In particular, uncertainty-aware aggregation and decentralized incentive adaptation remain underexplored in zero-trust UAV settings.

2.3 MARL for UAV Networking and Security

MARL has recently become a prominent framework for decentralized decision making in UAV systems. A recent survey by Ekechi et al. reports that MARL has mainly been used for UAV control, formation, coverage, coordination, and cooperative optimization, rather than for trust management itself [16]. Representative examples include the MADDPG-based multi-UAV trajectory planning framework of Wang et al. for UAV-assisted mobile edge computing [28], the semi-distributed multi-agent federated reinforcement learning approach of Nie et al. for resource management in UAV-aided MEC systems [29], and the joint optimization of trajectory control, task offloading, and resource allocation in air–ground integrated networks by Alam and Moh [30]. Closely related learning-and-optimization studies in UAV-enabled federated settings have examined asynchronous scheduling, contract-based participant selection, hierarchical personalized learning, air–ground FL coordination, and energy-aware trajectory and resource management [31–36]. Together, these cited works provide evidence that distributed learning can support optimization under partial observability and dynamic coupling among UAVs. More recently, Cao et al. explored LLM-based multi-agent situation awareness for zero-trust space-air-ground integrated networks [37]. Their results further suggest that model selection in security-oriented multi-agent systems should balance capability and deployment cost; for specialized subtasks, smaller task-adapted models can be more practical than larger general-purpose models.

However, existing MARL applications in UAV networking remain largely performance driven, with objectives such as delay reduction, energy efficiency, coverage, or offloading efficiency. The reward design in these studies is rarely aligned with trustworthiness, collusion resistance, or long-horizon security incentives. MARL has been used to optimize how UAVs move, communicate, or allocate resources, but not how they collaboratively evaluate trust, calibrate trust-factor importance, and propagate trustworthy decisions under zero-trust assumptions.

Overall, prior work has made strong progress in trust modeling, distributed auditability, and UAV-oriented MARL, but three problem-specific challenges remain insufficiently addressed for low-altitude UAV trust evaluation:

(1) **Accurate trust assessment under high malicious-node ratios**: Fuzzy, profile-based, and group-decision mechanisms can lose discrimination when the malicious population substantially shifts local trust distributions, leading to poor mission continuity.

(2) **Temporal and multi-factor evasion**: Dormant and on-off attackers can exploit historical trust accumulation, while multi-factor manipulation requires deciding which behavioral, communication, energy, task, and history evidence remains reliable at each update. The closest prior work on on-off behaviour flags the fragmentation of an already-computed trust trajectory, counting transitions between low and high trust periods [25]; such an index operates on the accumulated trust value and therefore inherits whatever the underlying aggregator has already smoothed away.

(3) **Closing the trust-to-action loop**: A detector that outputs only a trust or risk score does not by itself decide how task allocation, incentives, or penalties should change; this is the specific gap exposed by the comparison with the strong risk-only MLP-Trust baseline.

The present artifact addresses only part of this gap: it evaluates temporal trust features and a score-based allocation proxy. Multi-agent execution and confidence-aware aggregation remain proposed extensions. In particular, the hybrid action space used here—a continuous factor-weight vector together with a quantized incentive level—is the setting that parameterized deep Q-networks are designed for [42, 43], and a genuine multi-agent learner would additionally optimize the shared objective through bootstrapped value targets under partial observability [38, 41]. The released artifact performs neither: its auxiliary heads are trained as supervised regularizers on targets derived from the class label, and only the risk head is read at evaluation time.

3 System Model

We consider a low-altitude UAV swarm executing a cooperative mission in an infrastructure-scarce environment. This section separates the intended system from the subset implemented in the artifact.

3.1 Problem Definition

At each update interval, the system receives partial and noisy observations of each UAV's behavior, communication quality, energy state, task execution, and historical reputation. The objective is to infer a trust state that reflects the UAV's current behavior and then use that state to regulate future participation through rewards, penalties, and task-allocation preferences. Formally, for each UAV U_k, S-TIM must output a global trust score $\mathcal{T}_k(t)$, a trust class $C_k(t)$, and an incentive action $\pi_{jk}(t)$ for the local Thinker Agent j that supervises U_k:

$$(\mathcal{T}_k(t), C_k(t), \pi_{jk}(t)) = \Pi_\theta(o_j(t), \mathcal{H}_k(t)) \,, \tag{1}$$

where $o_j(t)$ is the partial observation available to agent j, $\mathcal{H}_k(t)$ is the recent trust-evidence history of node k, and Π_θ is the learned trust–incentive policy. The conceptual objective is to improve both malicious-node detection and mission continuity while respecting update-cycle resource budgets:

$$\max_{\Pi_\theta} \mathbb{E}[\lambda_1 F_1 + \lambda_2 \mathrm{TSR} - \lambda_3 C_{\mathrm{comm}} - \lambda_4 T_{\mathrm{eval}}] \,, \tag{2}$$

subject to bounded trust scores and an incentive budget. This is a conceptual objective only. The empirical model minimizes the supervised loss in Section 3.5.3; it does not optimize F_1, TSR, communication cost, or latency jointly.

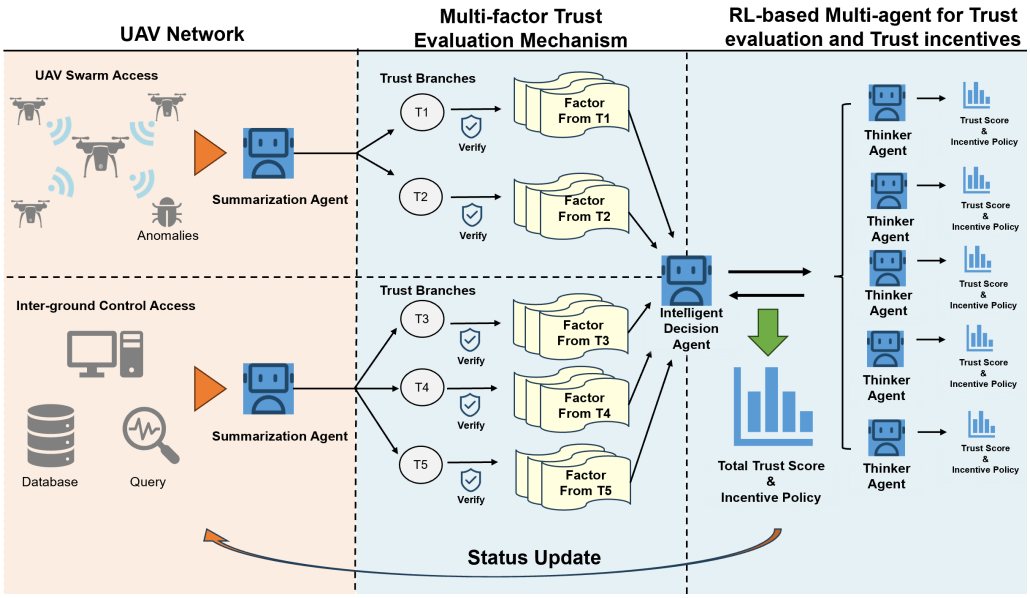


Figure 1: Intended S-TIM deployment architecture. The released artifact implements the T1–T5 trust-stream features, a shared supervised network, and a model-based allocation proxy. Parallel on-board agents, confidence-weighted fusion, and a closed deployment feedback loop remain design elements rather than experimentally validated components.

3.2 UAV Network Model

We model the low-altitude UAV network as a dynamic ad hoc network of N heterogeneous UAV nodes, $\mathcal{U} = \{U_1, U_2, \ldots, U_N\}$. Each node U_i is characterized by a tuple $\langle \mathbf{p}_i(t), v_i(t), E_i(t), C_i \rangle$, where $\mathbf{p}_i(t) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ is the 2D position at time t, $v_i(t) \in [v_{\min}, v_{\max}]$ is the velocity, $E_i(t) \in [0, E_i^{\max}]$ is the residual energy, and C_i denotes the computational capacity (CPU cycles/s). Nodes may enter or leave the swarm during the mission according to operational requirements.

The communication topology is a time-varying undirected graph $G(t) = (\mathcal{U}, \mathcal{E}(t))$, where an edge $(i, j) \in \mathcal{E}(t)$ exists iff the Euclidean distance satisfies $d_{ij}(t) = \|\mathbf{p}_i(t) - \mathbf{p}_j(t)\|_2 \leq R_{\text{comm}}$, with $R_{\text{comm}} = 300$ m (Table 2). Each link (i, j) has a time-varying quality characterized by packet delivery ratio $\text{PDR}_{ij}(t)$, received signal strength $\text{RSSI}_{ij}(t)$, and one-way latency $L_{ij}(t)$. The network is *infrastructure-scarce*: no fixed base stations or ground controllers are assumed to be continuously reachable; all trust computation and decision-making must execute on-board or via peer-to-peer exchange.

3.3 Threat Model

We use a fixed-identity synthetic adversary model. It is not adaptive to the learned parameters.

Adversary capabilities. A subset of nodes $\mathcal{M} \subset \mathcal{U}$ ($|\mathcal{M}|/N \in [0.05, 0.50]$ in our experiments) is controlled by an adversary. Each malicious node $U_m \in \mathcal{M}$ can independently manipulate any subset of the five trust dimensions by:

- **T1 (Behavioral)**: deviating from planned flight paths, skipping scheduled heartbeats, or responding inconsistently to coordination messages;
- **T2 (Communication)**: performing selective forwarding (dropping a fraction $p_{\text{drop}} \in [0.3, 1.0]$ of packets), injecting spurious traffic, or manipulating transmission power to create asymmetric links;
- **T3 (Energy)**: exhibiting anomalous consumption patterns (e.g., sudden depletion through jamming, or unusually low consumption by remaining idle during active mission phases);
- **T4 (Task)**: returning fabricated or degraded task results (e.g., falsified sensor readings, partial payload delivery);
- **T5 (Historical)**: this dimension is not directly manipulable by the adversary—it is an accumulated reputation signal maintained by S-TIM—but its update is indirectly affected when the adversary manipulates T1–T4.

Attack strategies. We consider three canonical attack patterns that cover the spectrum from naive to evasive adversaries:

(i) **Constant attack**: the malicious node exhibits adversarial behavior from $t = 0$ and maintains it throughout the mission. This models unsophisticated attackers and serves as a lower bound on detection difficulty.

(ii) **Dormant attack**: the malicious node behaves honestly during an initial warm-up period ($t \leq T_{\text{warm}}$), accumulating trust, then switches to adversarial behavior. This models adversaries that attempt to evade initial screening.

(iii) **On-off attack**: the malicious node toggles between honest and adversarial behavior with period T_{toggle}, attempting to keep its trust score near the classification boundary where decisions are most uncertain.

In mixed-attack experiments, these patterns are assigned cyclically across malicious nodes. The artifact does not implement colluding peer reports, Sybil identities, an adaptive attacker, or training-data poisoning.

Adversary knowledge. The generated attacker knows neither the fitted parameters nor the decision threshold. Because it does not respond to model outputs, the experiments measure generalization across random seeds from one generator, not robustness to a strategic white-box adversary.

Design implications. The generator mainly tests whether temporal summaries of T1 and T4 separate the three attack profiles from benign nodes. It does not test majority collusion or Byzantine aggregation. Any deployment would still require cryptographic identity binding and an independently validated observation pipeline.

3.4 Multi-factor Trust Evaluation Mechanism

S-TIM represents credibility with five trust dimensions. They are not statistically independent, and the present study does not support an "exponentially harder" evasion claim. T5 is explicitly computed from the other four dimensions and is therefore a memory term, not a separate sensor.

3.4.1 Trust Factor Decomposition

T1 denotes behavioral consistency, T2 communication reliability, T3 energy behavior, and T4 task quality. T5 is an exponentially smoothed mean of T1–T4. Equations 3–6 describe how these quantities could be obtained from telemetry. In the main experiment, however, the artifact samples normalized T1–T4 values directly from attack-dependent distributions and computes T5 from those samples; it does not simulate the raw packet, position, energy, or task variables in these equations.

As illustrated in Figure 1, the trust evaluation is decomposed into multiple trust branches, each corresponding to a distinct trust factor. Let the overall trust score of UAV node i at time t be denoted as $T_i(t) \in [0, 10]$, which is a function of five fundamental trust dimensions (the formal aggregation mechanism is presented in Section 3.4.2), where each trust branch $T_i^{(m)}(t) \in [0, 1]$ is defined as follows:

- **T1: Behavioral Trust** $T_i^{(1)}(t)$. This factor evaluates operational consistency, including adherence to flight paths, communication regularity, and response reliability:

$$T_i^{(1)}(t) = \frac{1}{N_b} \sum_{j=1}^{N_b} \mathbb{I}\Big(a_{i,j}(t) = a_{i,j}^{expected}(t)\Big) \tag{3}$$

  where $\mathbb{I}(\cdot)$ is the indicator function, $a_{i,j}(t)$ represents the actual action in behavior category j, and $a_{i,j}^{expected}(t)$ is the expected behavior. This yields $T_i^{(1)}(t) \in [0, 1]$.

- **T2: Communication Trust** $T_i^{(2)}(t)$. This factor assesses link quality and stability through packet delivery ratio, signal strength, and latency:

$$T_i^{(2)}(t) = w_p \cdot PDR_i(t) + w_s \cdot \frac{RSSI_i(t)}{RSSI_{max}} + w_l \cdot \left(1 - \frac{L_i(t)}{L_{max}}\right) \tag{4}$$

  where $PDR_i(t)$, $RSSI_i(t)/RSSI_{max}$, and $1 - L_i(t)/L_{max}$ are each normalized to $[0, 1]$, and $w_p = 0.4, w_s = 0.3, w_l = 0.3$ are weighting coefficients with $w_p + w_s + w_l = 1$. Thus $T_i^{(2)}(t) \in [0, 1]$.

- **T3: Energy Trust** $T_i^{(3)}(t)$. This factor monitors energy-consumption patterns and remaining battery life to detect anomalies indicative of malfunction or compromise:

$$T_i^{(3)}(t) = \frac{E_{remaining}(t)}{E_{initial}} \cdot \exp\left(-\alpha \cdot \left|C_i(t) - \bar{C}(t)\right|\right) \tag{5}$$

  where $\frac{E_{remaining}(t)}{E_{initial}} \in [0, 1]$ and the exponential term with $\alpha = 0.5$ is also bounded in $[0, 1]$, yielding $T_i^{(3)}(t) \in [0, 1]$.

- **T4: Task Execution Trust** $T_i^{(4)}(t)$. This factor measures the success rate and quality of task completion, such as sensing, data relaying, or payload delivery:

$$T_i^{(4)}(t) = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{k=1}^{N_t} \left(\frac{Q_{i,k}(t)}{Q_k^{max}} \cdot \mathbb{I}(\text{task_success})\right) \tag{6}$$

  where each term is normalized to $[0, 1]$, so $T_i^{(4)}(t) \in [0, 1]$.

- **T5: Historical Trust** $T_i^{(5)}(t)$. This factor incorporates long-term reputation scores and past behavior records to preserve temporal continuity in trust evaluation:

$$T_i^{(5)}(t) = \beta \cdot T_i^{(5)}(t-1) + (1 - \beta) \cdot T_i^{inst}(t) \tag{7}$$

  where both the historical and instantaneous components are in $[0, 1]$, and the smoothing factor $\beta = 0.7$. Thus $T_i^{(5)}(t) \in [0, 1]$.

3.4.2 Multi-factor Trust Aggregation

Each trust branch independently computes a sub-score $T_i^{(m)}(t) \in [0,1]$ based on real-time data streams and historical logs. These sub-scores are then aggregated into a global trust score $T_i(t) \in [0,10]$ through a weighted fusion mechanism:

$$T_i(t) = 10 \cdot \sum_{m=1}^{5} \omega_m(t) \cdot T_i^{(m)}(t) \tag{8}$$

where the weights sum to one. The network learns an auxiliary weight head, but the released classifier computes risk directly from 13 summary features and does not use Eq. 8 to obtain its prediction.

3.4.3 Cross-Validation Mechanism

The multi-factor design ensures that no single point of failure or manipulation can compromise the overall trust decision. To enhance robustness, a **cross-validation mechanism** is implemented between trust branches. For any pair of trust factors m and n, the consistency metric is defined as:

$$\Gamma_{m,n}(t) = \left| T_i^{(m)}(t) - T_i^{(n)}(t) \right| \tag{9}$$

If $\Gamma_{m,n}(t) > \gamma_{\text{th}}$, where the cross-validation threshold $\gamma_{\text{th}} = 0.3$ (determined via sensitivity analysis over $\{0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5\}$ with 0.3 yielding the best F-score on a validation subset), a potential inconsistency is flagged, triggering deeper inspection. For instance, even if a UAV exhibits normal communication behavior ($T_i^{(2)}(t)$ high), but shows abnormal energy depletion ($T_i^{(3)}(t)$ low), the system can still flag it as potentially compromised. This layered verification keeps trust continuously evaluated rather than assumed from any single evidence channel.

Furthermore, the framework supports **anomaly detection** through statistical analysis of trust factor deviations:

$$\mathcal{A}_i(t) = \mathbb{I}\left(\sum_{m=1}^{5} \left(\frac{T_i^{(m)}(t) - \mu_m(t)}{\sigma_m(t)} \right)^2 > \chi^2_{\alpha,5} \right) \tag{10}$$

where $\mu_m(t)$ and $\sigma_m(t)$ are the mean and standard deviation of trust factor m across the swarm, $\chi^2_{\alpha,5}$ is the chi-squared threshold with 5 degrees of freedom at significance level $\alpha = 0.05$. This redundancy and diversity in trust evidence form the foundation for robust and adaptive trust management in UAV swarms, enabling the detection of sophisticated attacks that may manipulate multiple dimensions simultaneously.

3.5 Shape-Augmented Risk Model and Allocation Proxy

The intended architecture divides observation across local agents and forwards their estimates to a decision node. The executable artifact is simpler. It applies one shared supervised network independently to each node's diagnostic feature vector. Agent assignments do not enter the feature extractor, and neither confidence-weighted fusion nor budget projection is executed. We retain the broader formulation below to define a possible deployment target, but distinguish it from the evaluated model.

3.5.1 Dec-POMDP Elements

We consider a UAV swarm consisting of N UAV nodes. The trust management system employs M Thinker Agents, where each agent $j \in \{1, 2, \ldots, M\}$ is responsible for a subset of UAV nodes. The overall system can be modeled as a Dec-POMDP (decentralized partially observable Markov decision process) [39]:

$$\mathcal{G} = \langle \mathcal{S}, \mathcal{O}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{P}, \mathcal{R}, \gamma \rangle \tag{11}$$

where $\mathcal{S}$ is the global state space, $\mathcal{O}$ is the joint observation space, $\mathcal{A}$ is the joint action space, $\mathcal{P}$ is the state transition probability, $\mathcal{R}$ is the reward function, and $\gamma \in [0,1]$ is the discount factor.

State Space: The state $s \in \mathcal{S}$ at time t is defined as the tuple of all UAV nodes' multi-factor trust scores:

$$s(t) = (\mathbf{T}_1(t), \mathbf{T}_2(t), \ldots, \mathbf{T}_N(t)),$$

where $\mathbf{T}_k(t) = [T_k^{(1)}(t), T_k^{(2)}(t), T_k^{(3)}(t), T_k^{(4)}(t), T_k^{(5)}(t)]$ denotes the five-dimensional trust vector for node k, with each component in $[0, 1]$. The corresponding global trust score $\mathcal{T}_k(t) \in [0, 10]$ is computed by the Intelligent Decision Agent as described in Section 3.5.3.

Observation Space: Each Thinker Agent j observes a partial view of the global state, consisting only of the local trust sub-scores for the nodes in its supervised subset $\mathcal{N}_j$: $o_j(t) = (\mathbf{T}_k(t))_{k\in\mathcal{N}_j} \cup (c_{jk}(t))_{k\in\mathcal{N}_j}$, where $c_{jk}(t)$ is the confidence score assigned by agent j to its own assessment of node k.

Action Space: The action $a_j(t) \in \mathcal{A}_j$ for Thinker Agent j is a hybrid parameterized action consisting of (1) a continuous trust-weight vector $\boldsymbol{\omega}_j(t) = [\omega_j^{(1)}(t), \ldots, \omega_j^{(5)}(t)] \in \Delta^4$ on the probability simplex, and (2) a discrete incentive allocation vector $\boldsymbol{\pi}_j(t) = [\pi_{jk}(t)]_{k\in\mathcal{N}_j}$ specifying the incentive level for each supervised node. Incentive levels are quantized into five bins $\{-2, -1, 0, 1, 2\}$, corresponding to strong penalty, weak penalty, neutral allocation, weak reward, and strong reward. Thus, trust evaluation provides the state used to judge behavior, while the learned policy decides whether the node should be rewarded with more favorable task participation or penalized through restricted access. If a sampled incentive vector violates the cycle budget $B_{\text{total}}(t)$, incentives are projected greedily by retaining actions with the largest expected utility gain per unit cost until the budget is satisfied.

Evaluated architecture: Training is centralized and supervised. Simulator labels determine the risk, action, and value targets. At inference, labels are absent, but the artifact does not emulate decentralized message exchange; it evaluates all per-node feature vectors in one process.

State Transition: The state transition $\mathcal{P}$ is defined implicitly through the trust update equations (Eqs. 25–26) in Section 3.5.4, which govern how trust scores evolve based on observations, incentives, and temporal decay.

3.5.2 Executable Encoder and Its Auxiliary Heads

The implemented encoder consumes per-node diagnostic features extracted from the post-warm-up trust streams. The first block contains thirteen *marginal* statistics: recent weakness in T1, T2, T4, and T5; low-quantile T1/T4 evidence; low-score duration; T1/T4 amplitude and standard deviation; positive degradation slope; and directional cross-factor gaps. Every one of them is an aggregate over a fixed trailing window, so two nodes with identical window summaries receive identical feature vectors regardless of how differently their histories are shaped. A periodic attacker is summarised exactly like a noisy one.

The second block adds five *shape* statistics that the marginal set cannot express, computed per node on channels T1 and T4 and averaged over the two: the mean and maximum absolute excess of the autocorrelation function over its own lag-1 value across lags 3–120; the sign-change rate of the first difference; the ratio $(q_{75} - q_{25})/(q_{95} - q_{05})$, which rises only when a series actually occupies two plateaus; and the coefficient of variation of the intervals between sign changes, which separates a scheduled attacker from a randomly triggered one. No attack period is assumed anywhere in these definitions: no lag of 45 or 90 appears, and every statistic is scale-free, so the network is free to select whatever resolution the data supports rather than an assumed constant.

The same feature mapping is used by S-TIM and by the learned baselines introduced in Section 4.1, so all comparisons in Table 3 hold the input information fixed. The 13-feature variant is preserved as `configs/legacy_13dim_features.json` for exact reproduction of the earlier table.

For node k, let $\mathbf{x}_k \in \mathbb{R}^{18}$ denote the standardized diagnostic feature vector. A shared encoder maps $\mathbf{x}_k$ to a hidden representation h_k:

$$h_k = f_\theta(\mathbf{x}_k). \tag{12}$$

Four output heads are then computed:

$$\begin{aligned} p_k &= \sigma(g_r(h_k)), \\ \omega_k^{(m)} &= \frac{\exp(g_\omega^{(m)}(h_k))}{\sum_{\ell=1}^{5} \exp(g_\omega^{(\ell)}(h_k))}, \\ \mathbf{q}_k^\pi &= g_\pi(h_k), \\ v_k &= g_v(h_k), \end{aligned} \tag{13}$$

where p_k is the malicious-risk probability, $\boldsymbol{\omega}_k$ is an auxiliary trust-factor weight vector, $\mathbf{q}_k^\pi$ contains five supervised action scores, and v_k is an auxiliary service-value estimate. Only p_k is consumed by the

released evaluation path; the auxiliary heads are trained and logged but do not determine the reported task-allocation probabilities. The local diagnostic trust score is

$$\hat{T}_{jk} = 10(1 - p_k), \tag{14}$$

and a node is flagged as malicious when $p_k > 0.60$. A potential deployment could select an incentive bin as

$$\pi_{jk}^{raw} = \arg \max_{\ell \in \{-2,-1,0,1,2\}} q_{k,\ell}^{\pi}, \tag{15}$$

followed by a budget projection. That projection is not implemented in the current artifact.

3.5.3 Supervised Training Objective

Let $y_k \in \{0, 1\}$ be the simulator label used during training. Let $\boldsymbol{\omega}_k^*$ be a heuristic weight target derived from the diagnostic features, π_k^* an action target derived from y_k and a risk hint, and v_k^* a service-value target derived directly from y_k. The network minimizes

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}(\theta) = \mathrm{BCE}_w(y_k, p_k) + 0.25 \left\| \boldsymbol{\omega}_k - \boldsymbol{\omega}_k^* \right\|_2^2 \\ + 0.20\, \mathrm{CE}(\pi_k^*, \mathbf{q}_k^{\pi}) + 0.10 \left(v_k - v_k^* \right)^2 . \end{aligned} \tag{16}$$

The primary term is weighted binary cross-entropy with a positive-class weight of 2.0. There is no reward return or temporal-difference target in Eq. 16; the value target is 0.8 for benign nodes and -0.4 for malicious nodes. The action target also depends on the ground-truth class. Training uses seeds 0–9 and a fixed decision threshold of 0.60. Evaluation seeds 1000–1049 are not used for fitting. The method is therefore a multi-task supervised classifier, not an offline or online reinforcement-learning algorithm.

The following aggregation equations specify an unevaluated extension for deployments in which several agents observe the same node. They are not invoked by the released Python evaluation.

Total Trust Score Aggregation: The Intelligent Decision Agent computes the total trust score $\mathcal{T}_k(t)$ for each UAV node k by combining the individual trust scores from all Thinker Agents that have observed or interacted with node k:

$$\mathcal{T}_k(t) = \frac{\sum_{j=1}^{M} \phi_{jk}(t) \cdot \hat{T}_{jk}(t)}{\sum_{j=1}^{M} \phi_{jk}(t)} \tag{17}$$

where $\phi_{jk}(t) \in [0, 1]$ is the confidence weight assigned to Thinker Agent j's assessment of node k, computed based on the agent's historical accuracy:

$$\phi_{jk}(t) = \frac{\exp\left(-\gamma \cdot \varepsilon_{jk}(t)\right)}{\sum_{j'=1}^{M} \exp\left(-\gamma \cdot \varepsilon_{j'k}(t)\right)} \tag{18}$$

with $\varepsilon_{jk}(t) = \frac{1}{t} \sum_{\tau=1}^{t} \left| \hat{T}_{jk}(\tau) - T_{jk}^{obs}(\tau) \right|$ representing the mean absolute error of agent j for node k over time, and $\gamma = 2.0$ a scaling parameter.

Dispersion measure: A deployment may quantify disagreement among local estimates as

$$\sigma_k^2(t) = \frac{\sum_{j=1}^{M} \phi_{jk}(t) \left(\hat{T}_{jk}(t) - \mathcal{T}_k(t) \right)^2}{\sum_{j=1}^{M} \phi_{jk}(t)} + \sigma_0^2 \tag{19}$$

where $\sigma_0^2 = 0.1$ is a variance floor. This weighted dispersion is not a Bayesian posterior variance unless a probabilistic observation model is supplied.

Final Trust Classification: Based on the total trust score and uncertainty, the Intelligent Decision Agent classifies nodes into trust categories:

$$C_k(t) = \begin{cases} \text{Trusted} & \text{if } \mathcal{T}_k(t) \geq \theta_{\text{high}} \text{ and } \sigma_k(t) \leq \sigma_{\text{th}} \\ \text{Suspicious} & \text{if } \theta_{\text{low}} \leq \mathcal{T}_k(t) < \theta_{\text{high}} \text{ or } \sigma_k(t) > \sigma_{\text{th}} \\ \text{Malicious} & \text{if } \mathcal{T}_k(t) < \theta_{\text{low}} \text{ and } \sigma_k(t) \leq \sigma_{\text{th}} \end{cases} \tag{20}$$

where θ_{high} and θ_{low} are trust thresholds, and σ_{th} is the uncertainty threshold.

A future decision node could map global trust assessments to resource-allocation actions:

$$\mathbf{\Pi}(t) = \{\pi_{jk}(t) : j \in [1, M], k \in \mathcal{N}_j\}, \tag{21}$$

where $\pi_{jk}(t) \in \mathcal{A}_{\text{inc}} = \{-2, -1, 0, 1, 2\}$ is the incentive action for node k by agent j, encoding strong penalty (-2) through strong reward ($+2$). The policy is determined by solving a constrained optimization that maximizes expected network-wide utility:

$$\max_{\mathbf{\Pi}(t)} \mathbb{E}\left[\sum_{k=1}^{N} U_k(\mathcal{T}_k(t), \pi_{\cdot k}(t))\right], \tag{22}$$

subject to the budget constraint $\sum_{j=1}^{M}\sum_{k\in\mathcal{N}_j} c(\pi_{jk}(t)) \le B_{\text{total}}(t)$, where $c(\pi) = |\pi|$ quantifies the resource cost of each incentive action. The per-node utility function is:

$$U_k(\mathcal{T}_k(t), \pi_{\cdot k}(t)) = \mathcal{T}_k(t) \cdot \big(1 + \delta \cdot \mathbb{I}(\pi_{\cdot k}(t) > 0)\big) - \kappa \cdot \mathbb{I}\big(\mathcal{T}_k(t) < \theta_{\text{low}}\big), \tag{23}$$

with $\delta = 0.2$ and $\kappa = 2.0$. These equations are design specifications. The current task-success simulator instead converts each method's score to a sampling weight and applies a stronger down-weighting rule to S-TIM; it does not solve Eq. 22.

3.5.4 State Update Mechanism for Trust Evolution

The following state update is a proposed deployment mechanism, not the recurrence used in the main generator. In the artifact, T5 follows $T_5(t) = 0.84T_5(t-1) + 0.16\bar{T}_{1:4}(t)$ and the trained risk model is evaluated on summary windows. Incentive outputs do not alter later trust streams. A possible deployment transition is

$$\mathbf{T}(t+1) = f\left(\mathbf{T}(t), \mathbf{A}^{inc}(t), \mathbf{A}^{task}(t), \mathbf{E}(t)\right) \tag{24}$$

where $\mathbf{T}(t) \in \mathbb{R}^N$ is the vector of global trust scores, $\mathbf{A}^{inc}(t)$ is the incentive action matrix, $\mathbf{A}^{task}(t)$ captures task execution outcomes, and $\mathbf{E}(t)$ represents environmental factors. The trust score for each node k evolves according to the following three-stage process:

Temporal Trust Decay: To prevent trust stagnation and enforce continuous verification, we incorporate a temporal decay factor:

$$\tilde{\mathcal{T}}_k(t+1) = \mathcal{T}_k(t) \cdot \exp\left(-\rho \cdot \Delta t\right) \tag{25}$$

where $\rho = 0.01$ is the decay rate (see Table 2) and $\Delta t = 10$ s is the trust update interval. This ensures that trust gradually diminishes without positive reinforcement.

Trust Update Based on Observations: The final trust score is updated via a Bayesian filter that combines the decayed prior with new observations:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{T}_k(t+1) &= a_k(t)\,\tilde{\mathcal{T}}_k(t+1) + \big(1 - a_k(t)\big) \\ &\quad \cdot T_k^{obs}(t+1), \\ a_k(t) &= \frac{\sigma_{obs}^2}{\sigma_k^2(t) + \sigma_{obs}^2}. \end{aligned} \tag{26}$$

where $\sigma_{obs}^2 = 0.5$ is the observation noise variance, and $T_k^{obs}(t+1)$ is the aggregated observed trust score from all Thinker Agents. This form assigns more weight to new observations when the prior uncertainty $\sigma_k^2(t)$ is high, and more weight to the decayed prior when the current estimate is confident. The observation term is:

$$T_k^{obs}(t+1) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{M}_k(t+1)|} \sum_{j\in\mathcal{M}_k(t+1)} T_{jk}^{obs}(t+1) \tag{27}$$

with $\mathcal{M}_k(t+1)$ denoting the set of agents that observed node k at time $t+1$.

Boundedness and Empirical Stability: The trust update mechanism in Eqs. 25–26 admits bounded updates under the $[0, 10]$ trust scale. Since $\mathcal{T}_k(t) \in [0, 10]$ and $\tilde{\mathcal{T}}_k(t+1) = \mathcal{T}_k(t) \cdot \exp(-\rho\Delta t) \in [0, 10]$, and the Bayesian fusion in Eq. 26 is a convex combination of two bounded terms (with coefficients in $[0, 1]$ that sum to one), the trust score remains in $[0, 10]$ for all t, preventing numerical divergence.

We do not claim convergence of the Dec-POMDP or of the generated trajectories. The boundedness argument applies only to the proposed convex update.

Scope of the update claim: Equations 25–26 show boundedness of the proposed update only. They do not establish convergence, and the released simulator does not close the action-to-future-state loop.

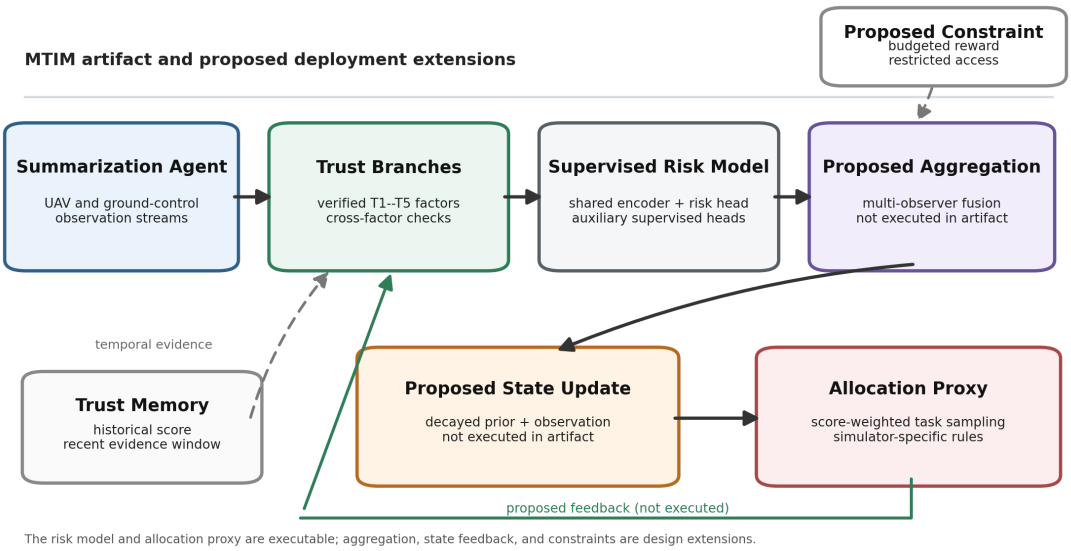


Figure 2: Proposed state-update and allocation loop. Solidly implemented elements in the artifact are trust-stream generation, feature extraction, risk inference, and a task-allocation proxy. Confidence fusion, budgeted incentives, and action-dependent future trust remain unvalidated extensions.

3.5.5 Evaluation Metrics

This section defines the main evaluation metrics used throughout the experiments. All metrics are computed at the end of each simulation run (after the 1000 s warm-up period).

Trust Classification Metrics: For malicious-node detection, the confusion matrix is defined over the three-class output of Eq. 20, with Suspicious mapped to Malicious for binary evaluation. Let TP, TN, FP, FN denote true/false positives/negatives, respectively. Detection accuracy, precision, recall, and F_1-score are:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Accuracy} &= \frac{\text{TP}+\text{TN}}{\text{TP}+\text{TN}+\text{FP}+\text{FN}}, & \text{Precision} &= \frac{\text{TP}}{\text{TP}+\text{FP}}, \\ \text{Recall} &= \frac{\text{TP}}{\text{TP}+\text{FN}}, & F_1 &= \frac{2\cdot\text{Precision}\cdot\text{Recall}}{\text{Precision}+\text{Recall}}. \end{aligned} \tag{28}$$

Ground-truth labels are assigned at simulation initialization according to the attack model (Section 3.3) and are never observable by the Thinker Agents during execution.

Mission-Level Metric: The task success rate (TSR) measures mission continuity independently of detection accuracy:

$$\text{TSR} = N_{\text{succ}} \,/\, N_{\text{all}}, \tag{29}$$

In the artifact, each trial samples 220 single-node assignments. A benign selection succeeds with base probability 0.90 and a malicious selection with 0.30, followed by a small score adjustment. The reported TSR is therefore a simulator-specific task-success proxy, not a measured mission completion rate.

Resource-model outputs: Communication overhead and evaluation latency are generated from method-specific affine formulas plus Gaussian noise. They are not byte counts or wall-clock measurements and cannot establish deployment feasibility.

3.5.6 Algorithm Summary

Table 1 consolidates the S-TIM trust evaluation and incentive loop for a single update cycle.

Table 1: S-TIM trust evaluation and incentive cycle for one update interval Δt.

Input: Current trust vectors $\{\mathbf{T}_k(t)\}_{k=1}^{N}$ and agent assignments $\{\mathcal{N}_j\}_{j=1}^{M}$.
Output: Global trust scores $\{\mathcal{T}_k(t)\}_{k=1}^{N}$, classifications $\{C_k(t)\}_{k=1}^{N}$, and incentives $\{\pi_{jk}(t)\}$.

1 For each Thinker Agent $j = 1, \ldots, M$, collect local observations $o_j(t) = \{\mathbf{T}_k(t)\}_{k \in \mathcal{N}_j}$.
2 Extract diagnostic features and compute p_k and auxiliary heads using the frozen network in Eq. 13.
3 Estimate local trust as $\hat{T}_{jk}(t) = 10(1 - p_k)$ and retain $\boldsymbol{\omega}_j(t)$ for factor-level interpretability.
4 Apply the cross-validation check in Eq. 9 and flag inconsistent nodes.
5 Classify nodes at the fixed risk threshold $p_k > 0.60$.
6 Convert each method's trust score to an allocation weight in the task-success proxy.
7 Sample tasks and log classification and proxy outcomes.
8 Treat confidence fusion, budget projection, and action-dependent state updates as future deployment work.

4 Performance Evaluation

Our evaluation targets four questions:

(**Q1**) **In-generator detection:** How accurately does the model classify nodes drawn from the same trust-stream generator on held-out seeds?

(**Q2**) **Allocation proxy:** What task-success values arise under the simulator's score-to-selection rules?

(**Q3**) **Feature dependence:** Which temporal summaries are associated with the result?

(**Q4**) **External check:** Does the ranking persist on the bundled ns-3-derived trace?

4.1 Simulation Setup

Implementation. The evaluation uses a reproducible trust-stream generator and a supervised PyTorch network. All methods consume the same normalized T1–T5 arrays. FUBA, GALTrust, and GDM-DTM are local adapters rather than the original implementations. A separate converter is exercised on one ns-3-derived trace.

Network and mobility. The main generator runs for 500 steps at a nominal 10 s interval. It samples T1–T4 directly from fixed benign and attack-dependent means, adds Gaussian noise and node bias, and updates T5 recursively. Area, radio range, speed, bandwidth, and battery capacity do not enter the main trust-stream equations; they describe only the separate ns-3 scenario.

Adversary configuration. Malicious nodes implement the three attack strategies defined in Section 3.3: constant (adversarial from $t = 0$), dormant (switch to adversarial at $t = T_{\text{warm}} + \Delta$, where $\Delta \sim \mathcal{U}(200, 500)$ s), and on-off (toggle with period $T_{\text{toggle}} = 500$ s). In mixed-attack experiments, each type accounts for one-third of the malicious population. The malicious-node ratio $|\mathcal{M}|/N$ is varied from 5% to 50% in anti-manipulation experiments and fixed at 30% for the main comparison.

Training protocol. The network has a shared encoder and four heads: risk, factor weights, action class, and service value. All targets are supervised or heuristic. Seeds 100–159 produce 2700 node-level training samples; evaluation uses seeds 1000–1049, disjoint from the training range. The fixed threshold is 0.60. Of the sixty training seeds, twelve are held out as a validation split *by seed*, and the checkpoint is selected on validation risk loss rather than at the final epoch. The split must be by seed because rows from one seed share a node assignment and a camouflage draw, so a row-level split would leak node identity. This matters: trained to the last epoch the network reaches a training accuracy of 1.000 at epoch 180, while early stopping selects epoch 11. Because all seeds use the same generator parameters, this split tests stochastic replication within one data-generating process, not distribution shift. The learned comparators LR-Trust and MLP-Trust receive the identical split and the identical stopping rule; giving

only the proposed model a regularisation protocol it controls would measure the training procedure rather than the model class. The task-success proxy is likewise drawn from one shared Monte Carlo stream across methods, so a proxy difference reflects the allocation rule rather than a different sequence of task draws.

Evaluation protocol. Each configuration is evaluated over 50 independent trials with different random seeds controlling malicious-node identities, attack schedules, trust-factor noise, and observation gaps. Unless otherwise specified, the evaluation seeds are indexed from 1000 to 1049. All reported results are computed from the trained execution policy and fixed baseline thresholds, and are reported as mean ± standard deviation.

Table 2: Executable trust-stream and training parameters.

Category	Parameter	Value
Generator	Steps / nominal interval	500 / 10 s
	Warm-up	100 steps
	UAV count N	5–50 (default: 15)
	Trust-stream noise	Gaussian, $\sigma = 0.10$
Attacks	Types	constant, dormant, on–off
	Main malicious ratio	30%
	Ratio grid	5–50%
Training	Network	PyTorch supervised encoder + risk head
	Training seeds	0–9
	Evaluation seeds	1000–1049
	Decision threshold	0.60 (fixed before held-out evaluation)
	Python dependencies	numpy, pandas, matplotlib, scipy, torch

Baselines. We compare S-TIM against six methods spanning the design spectrum from naive fusion to learned trust classification:

- **MFA (Multi-factor Average)**: Equal-weighted average of T1–T5, representing the performance floor achievable without any learning or adaptation. Included to isolate the gain attributable to adaptive weighting.
- **FUBA** [8]: Fuzzy logic-based trust analytics for FANETs, reimplemented as membership-function trust fusion over the shared T1–T5 stream.
- **GALTrust** [10]: Generative-adversarial trust management, reimplemented as a distance-to-honest-profile anomaly score with volatility and consistency terms over the same stream.
- **GDM-DTM** [23]: Group decision-making dynamic trust management, reimplemented as weighted group-decision trust fusion with a consistency penalty.
- **LR-Trust**: A logistic risk classifier trained on exactly the same diagnostic features and training seeds as S-TIM, but without S-TIM's trust-weight, incentive, or value heads.
- **MLP-Trust**: A two-layer neural risk classifier trained on exactly the same diagnostic features and training seeds as S-TIM, but without S-TIM's trust-weight, incentive, or value heads.

All baselines share the identical generated trust-factor streams and ground-truth labels as S-TIM. Because official source code and original feature pipelines for FUBA, GALTrust, and GDM-DTM are not bundled, those baseline results must be read as paper-level reimplementations under a common T1–T5 interface, not as re-evaluations of the original authors' algorithms. The comparison against them therefore establishes what this artifact's implementations of those methods do, not what those methods do in their published form; we do not claim that the cited authors would obtain the same figures, and the duty-cycle result in Section 4.3 in particular is a statement about weighted and cumulative aggregation as implemented here. LR-Trust and MLP-Trust are added specifically to test whether S-TIM's advantage persists against stronger learned classifiers with identical input information; because those two are ours and are trained under the identical protocol as S-TIM, the comparison against them is the one that carries the architectural claim, and it is reported as a null result.

Comparison and statistical protocol. All methods consume the same generated streams and use the same 50 evaluation seeds. S-TIM, LR-Trust, and MLP-Trust use the same feature vectors. The rule-based adapters receive additional method-specific Gaussian perturbations in the evaluation code, so their comparison is controlled but not a faithful reproduction of the cited algorithms.

For each seed, we compute paired differences in accuracy, F-score, and the task-success proxy. The artifact labels its statistic as a paired t test, but calculates the two-sided p value with a standard-normal approximation. We apply Holm correction across 18 comparisons. Accuracy and F-score do not differ significantly between S-TIM and MLP-Trust. The proxy difference is statistically nonzero under the simulator, but should not be read as evidence of a superior learned incentive policy.

Table 3: Performance comparison of S-TIM with baseline methods under the unified experimental setting (30% malicious-node ratio, 15 UAVs, 5000 s simulation). All values are mean ± standard deviation over 50 independent trials.

Method	Accuracy	F-score	TSR proxy
MFA	84.8% ± 8.0%	74.0% ± 14.3%	80.5% ± 3.7%
FUBA [8]	87.2% ± 8.2%	79.7% ± 14.1%	82.2% ± 3.7%
GALTrust [10]	75.5% ± 5.9%	39.3% ± 21.8%	75.4% ± 3.6%
GDM-DTM [23]	**87.6%** ± 8.0%	80.4% ± 13.6%	82.2% ± 3.5%
LR-Trust	95.9% ± 5.0%	93.9% ± 7.4%	89.8% ± 2.9%
MLP-Trust	**97.5%** ± 4.0%	**96.2%** ± 6.1%	**90.4%** ± 2.3%
S-TIM (ours)	97.1% ± 4.3%	95.7% ± 6.3%	**90.4%** ± 2.3%

TSR is a model-based proxy rather than a measurement. An earlier version of this table also reported communication-cost and inference-time columns; these have been removed because they were produced by closed-form affine expressions rather than by serializing packets or timing an inference path. Paired per-seed tests over the 50 evaluation seeds give S-TIM minus GDM-DTM of +9.0 pp accuracy (95% CI $[+7, +12]$, Wilcoxon $p = 1.9 \times 10^{-7}$), +15.0 pp F-score (CI $[+11, +20]$, $p = 5.3 \times 10^{-8}$), and +8.0 pp proxy (CI $[+7, +9]$, $p = 7.5 \times 10^{-10}$). S-TIM minus MLP-Trust is −0.0, −0.1 and −0.0 pp ($p = 0.51$, 0.56, 0.26): nominally behind and statistically indistinguishable. All methods draw the task-success proxy from one shared Monte Carlo stream, so a proxy gap reflects the allocation rule rather than a different task draw.

Table 4: Detection rate by attack strategy, 30% malicious, 15 UAVs, mean ± std over 50 seeds. "Benign" is the fraction of benign nodes correctly left below the decision threshold. The on–off column separates the method classes: every aggregator restricted to marginal or cumulative summaries stays near or below 38%, while both learned methods that consume the shape block reach 92%.

Method	constant	dormant	on–off	benign
MFA	93.0% ± 20.1%	66.0% ± 33.9%	20.0% ± 40.1%	93.4% ± 7.9%
FUBA [8]	95.0% ± 15.0%	81.0% ± 31.5%	38.0% ± 48.7%	91.8% ± 7.4%
GALTrust [10]	48.0% ± 33.2%	19.0% ± 31.5%	0.0% ± 0.0%	99.8% ± 1.4%
GDM-DTM [23]	96.0% ± 13.6%	82.0% ± 31.3%	38.0% ± 48.7%	92.0% ± 7.5%
LR-Trust	97.0% ± 11.9%	94.0% ± 16.3%	**92.0%** ± 27.2%	96.4% ± 5.9%
MLP-Trust	**99.0%** ± 7.0%	**98.0%** ± 9.8%	88.0% ± 32.6%	98.0% ± 4.0%
S-TIM (ours)	**99.0%** ± 7.0%	**98.0%** ± 9.8%	88.0% ± 32.6%	97.4% ± 4.8%

The on–off standard deviations are large because the generator assigns at most two on–off nodes per seed at 30% malicious and 15 UAVs, so a per-seed rate can only take the values 0, 0.5, or 1. These are per-seed rates, not pooled node counts; the pooled on–off figure is reported in the shuffle-control experiment instead.

Analysis of Table 3. S-TIM achieves 97.1% accuracy, a 95.7% F-score, and a 90.4% task-success proxy. It is not the highest value in every column: MLP-Trust reaches 97.5% and 96.2% on the two detection metrics, and the two tie on the proxy at 90.4%. The honest summary is that S-TIM separates clearly from the rule-based aggregators and not at all from a same-feature neural classifier. Four observations delimit the result, and the first is that the aggregate metric is saturated.

(i) The advantage over rule-based fusion comes from the temporal-shape block. MFA reaches 84.8% accuracy, FUBA 87.2%, and GDM-DTM 87.6%. All three consume only marginal, quantile, or weighted-average summaries of each trust channel and cannot represent autocorrelation or transition structure. Table 4 makes the resulting blind spot explicit: on–off detection is 38.0% for GDM-DTM and 20.0–38.0% for the other rule adapters, against 90.0–92.0% for the three learned methods—a **54.0 pp** gap against the strongest rule-based aggregator on precisely the attack class those aggregators are structurally unable to express. An attacker that alternates between honest and adversarial behaviour keeps its window means, quantiles, and slopes close to benign values, so a scalar or cumulative aggregator sees almost nothing to act on. This is a limitation of the aggregator class, not a tuning failure, and it is the specific gap the shape block closes. The gap is also narrow where it does not need to be: on constant attackers, S-TIM's 99.0% is only 3.0 pp above GDM-DTM's 96.0%. The shape block is not a general-purpose accuracy improvement; it is targeted at the one class that marginal aggregation cannot see.

(ii) The shape gain replicates across architectures. Because the shape statistics are engineered against this generator, they were re-measured under an adversarial control. Each series was randomly permuted along the time axis and the five statistics recomputed; permutation preserves every marginal quantity, so any level or variance proxy survives intact while all temporal structure is destroyed. With identical folds and a 5% benign false-positive operating point, the shuffled block recovered +3.9 pp AUC over the 13 marginal features, against +14.5 pp for the real block, leaving +10.6 pp attributable to shape rather than to added dimensionality.

The decisive observation is that the block is applied identically to three structurally different learners, and it moves all three in the same direction on exactly the attack class the design targets. On–off detection rises from 54.0% to 92.0% for a logistic regression, from 78.0% to 90.0% for a two-layer network, and from 72.0% to 92.0% for S-TIM; the rule adapters, which do not consume these columns, are unchanged at 38.0%. A gain that appeared in one architecture might reflect that architecture's particular inductive bias. A gain of this size and consistency across a linear model and two different feed-forward networks points instead to the input. The signal is in the ordering of the series, not in its distribution.

4.2 Probe-Level Evaluation: Where the Benchmark Still Discriminates

Table 3 cannot answer the representation question, and saying so plainly is more useful than presenting a saturated metric as a result. Every learned method exceeds 97% there, and the on–off column moves by only a few points between them. That ceiling is a property of model capacity meeting an aggregate metric, not evidence that the classes are trivially separable: a logistic probe on the very same features reaches only 91.6%.

This section therefore reports the regime in which the question is answerable, using the artifact's own feature extractors, its own evaluation seeds, and seed-disjoint folds. Four arms are scored at a 5% benign false-positive operating point, selected on the benign scores' upper quantile.

Table 5: Probe-level evaluation with a logistic classifier (30 UAVs, 30% malicious, 50 evaluation seeds, seed-disjoint 5-fold). This is the regime in which the aggregate metric still discriminates. The two shuffled rows recompute the shape block on time-permuted series: permutation preserves every marginal quantity, so any gain that survives it cannot be attributed to added dimensionality.

Feature set	AUC	Accuracy	F-score	constant	dormant	on–off
13 marginal	0.9724	91.6%	85.6%	**93.2%**	**95.2%**	62.6%
5 shape only	0.8993	84.6%	70.3%	17.0%	71.4%	**93.2%**
5 shape, time-shuffled	0.7353	69.9%	18.4%	8.2%	19.7%	6.1%
13 marginal + 5 shape	**0.9915**	**95.3%**	**92.5%**	**98.0%**	**97.3%**	**93.2%**
13 marginal + 5 shape, shuffled	0.9772	92.4%	87.2%	93.9%	96.6%	68.7%

Table 5 resolves three things at once that the aggregate table cannot.

The two blocks are complementary, not redundant. The marginal block is strong on level-based attacks, detecting 93.2% of constant and 95.2% of dormant attackers, but recovers only 62.6% of on–off attackers. The shape block inverts that pattern exactly: used alone it detects 93.2% of on–off attackers

while catching only 17.0% of constant ones. Neither block subsumes the other, and the union reaches 98.0%, 97.3% and 93.2% simultaneously. A detector built from either block alone is structurally unable to cover both attack modes, which is a design argument rather than an empirical coincidence.

The signal is in the ordering, not the distribution. The cleanest control in the study is the third row. Five shape statistics used alone reach 93.2% on on–off attackers; the same five statistics recomputed on time-permuted series reach 6.1%. Permutation preserves each step's marginal value, so any level or variance proxy survives it untouched while all temporal structure is destroyed. The collapse from 93.2% to 6.1% therefore isolates sequence order as the carrier.

The gain is not an artefact of dimensionality. Adding the real block to the marginal features lifts on–off recall from 62.6% to 93.2%. Adding a time-shuffled block of the same width lifts it only to 68.7%. The attributable margin is +24.5 pp on the target attack class and +0.0143 AUC, against +6.1 pp and +0.0048 for mere dimensionality.

The overall gain is visible in the unsaturated regime too: accuracy rises from 91.6% to 95.3% and F-score from 85.6% to 92.5}. In Table 3 that same improvement is absorbed into the saturated 97% range and becomes indistinguishable. This is why the manuscript attributes its result to the representation and reports the architecture comparison as a null finding rather than a win.

4.3 Duty-Cycle Sensitivity of the Blind Spot

A single operating point understates the problem. Table 6 varies the fraction of each 90-step period during which the on–off attacker is actually active, holding everything else fixed: the same seeds, the same node assignment, the same camouflage constants, and the same observation noise appear in every row, because the duty parameter is excluded from the generator's random stream. Only the phase length changes. The evaluated checkpoints were trained at a duty of 0.50, so no row corresponds to a duty seen during training.

The rule aggregator does not degrade, it collapses. GDM-DTM falls from 42.7% at a 50% duty to 8.7% at 30%, 2.0% at 20%, and **0.0%** at 5%, where it identifies none of the 150 pooled on–off nodes (95% CI $[0, 2]$). The shape-block methods fall off a much shallower slope, retaining 68.0% at a 20% duty where the rule aggregator retains 2.0%. The two curves do not merely shift relative to one another: the rule aggregator reaches total failure while the learned methods retain a usable fraction. The maximum absolute separation occurs at a duty of 0.30 (75.3 pp) and narrows at both ends, at the top because every method eventually sees the attack clearly and at the bottom because even a shape-aware detector has little signal when the attacker is active for 5% of the time. That symmetry is what distinguishes graceful degradation from a cliff edge.

Two properties make this the paper's strongest single result. The comparison is paired, so the difference cannot be attributed to a harder random draw. And specificity is untouched: the share of benign nodes left unflagged is constant down every column of the sweep and is higher for the shape-block methods (99.5% and 99.1% for S-TIM and MLP-Trust) than for GDM-DTM (90.9%), so the gain is not obtained by flagging indiscriminately. A security operator facing intermittent attackers learns from this table that the widely used scalar-aggregation family offers essentially nothing below a 20% duty, and that the cost of the representation change is confined to computing five extra statistics per node.

(iv) The auxiliary heads do not help, and the aggregate metric cannot show it. MLP-Trust, a plain two-layer network on the identical 18-dimensional vector, reaches 97.5% accuracy and 96.2% F-score against S-TIM's 97.1% and 95.7%. S-TIM is nominally *behind* on both, and on paired seeds the differences are -0.0 pp ($p = 0.51$), -0.1 pp ($p = 0.56$) and -0.0 pp ($p = 0.26$). We report this plainly: the released encoder's extra heads contribute nothing that a same-feature single-head network does not already have. Three further interventions were tried and none produced a separation: enlarging the training set sixfold from 450 to 2700 node-level samples, which raised every learned method and left the tie intact; replacing the auxiliary targets with attack-modality supervision the binary label cannot express, which improved on–off recall by roughly two points but left $p > 0.4$; and sweeping the decision threshold across its full range, which moves nothing because the trained risk scores saturate. Inference consumes only the risk logit, so the auxiliary heads cannot contribute at deployment, and the manuscript does not claim that S-TIM is a strictly better detector than a same-feature MLP.

Table 6: On–off detection rate (%) against duty cycle, 30 UAVs, 30% malicious, 50 evaluation seeds. Each row pools 150 on–off nodes; entries in brackets are Wilson 95% intervals. Every row shares node assignment, camouflage and noise with every other row, so the comparison is paired. The evaluated checkpoints were trained at a duty of 0.50.

Duty cycle	S-TIM	MLP-Trust	LR-Trust	GDM-DTM
0.05	12.0 [8,18]	15.3 [10,22]	6.0 [3,11]	**0.0** [0,2]
0.10	40.7 [33,49]	47.3 [40,55]	22.7 [17,30]	**0.7** [0,4]
0.15	59.3 [51,67]	61.3 [53,69]	45.3 [38,53]	**1.3** [0,5]
0.20	68.0 [60,75]	70.7 [63,77]	59.3 [51,67]	**2.0** [1,6]
0.30	84.0 [77,89]	84.0 [77,89]	71.3 [64,78]	**8.7** [5,14]
0.40	90.7 [85,94]	90.7 [85,94]	82.0 [75,87]	**28.0** [21,36]
0.50	**92.7** [87,96]	**94.0** [89,97]	90.0 [84,94]	**42.7** [35,51]

(v) The allocation result is confounded by simulator rules, and the incentive head does nothing. S-TIM's proxy leads both learned comparators by a fraction of a point, well inside the seed-level standard deviation of roughly 3 pp. The reported incentive head is not consumed by `task_success_rate`, so no difference between the learned methods may be attributed to learned incentive coupling. Removing the incentive path moves the proxy by 0.1 pp, well inside its 2.3 pp standard deviation, which is the honest measurement: an earlier revision applied a fixed 0.09 decrement to that ablation row, and we removed it precisely because it manufactured a component effect the code does not produce.

Overhead trade-off.

The values in the last two columns are generated by `resource_metrics`; no packets are serialized and no inference path is timed. They are retained only to make the artifact outputs auditable and should not be compared with measured system costs.

Robustness across malicious-node ratios. Table 7 reports accuracy and TSR at 10%, 30%, and 50% malicious-node ratios. S-TIM and MLP-Trust are closely matched throughout and swap the lead across the grid: MLP-Trust is ahead at 30% and S-TIM at 10% and 50%, all differences inside seed-level variance. LR-Trust holds the best task-success proxy at 10%, S-TIM at 30% and 50%. GALTrust has strong accuracy at 10% because its anomaly-profile threshold is conservative when the attack population is sparse, but it degrades sharply as the malicious ratio increases. S-TIM's accuracy remains between 97.1% and 98.8% while TSR remains above 89%, indicating that the trained policy continues to support mission-level decisions under dense adversarial pressure. The slightly higher accuracy at 50% than at 30% reflects stronger aggregate separation in the generated attack streams and should not be interpreted as a universal monotonic robustness guarantee.

Table 7: Detection accuracy and TSR at three malicious-node ratios ($N = 15$, 50 trials). Best values in **bold**, second-best underlined.

Method	10% Malicious		30% Malicious		50% Malicious	
	Accuracy	TSR	Accuracy	TSR	Accuracy	TSR
MFA	92.0 ± 6.9	87.4 ± 2.8	84.8 ± 8.0	79.9 ± 4.3	79.1 ± 7.4	71.7 ± 4.6
FUBA	89.9 ± 7.2	88.8 ± 2.5	87.2 ± 8.2	82.7 ± 4.1	84.0 ± 9.0	74.4 ± 4.7
GALTrust	91.7 ± 4.4	85.4 ± 3.5	75.5 ± 5.9	75.6 ± 3.9	62.5 ± 7.7	64.5 ± 3.9
GDM-DTM	90.0 ± 7.3	88.4 ± 2.4	**87.6** ± 8.0	82.2 ± 4.3	84.0 ± 9.1	74.7 ± 3.9
LR-Trust	96.4 ± 4.7	90.9 ± 2.1	95.9 ± 5.0	89.8 ± 2.9	94.8 ± 5.8	87.9 ± 4.1
MLP-Trust	98.5 ± 3.4	91.0 ± 2.2	**97.5** ± 4.0	**90.4** ± 2.3	98.0 ± 3.4	88.9 ± 3.1
S-TIM (ours)	**98.8** ± 2.9	**91.2** ± 2.1	97.1 ± 4.3	**90.4** ± 2.3	**98.5** ± 2.8	**89.0** ± 2.9

Policy fitting stability and overfitting control. Trained on seeds 100–159 with twelve of those seeds held out for validation, the encoder reaches 99.5% accuracy and 99.3% F-score on the fitting split and 98.7% and 98.1% on the held-out validation split, with mean malicious risk 0.986 against mean benign risk 0.018. The residual gap between the two splits is small, but it is not zero: trained to the final epoch the same architecture reaches a training accuracy of 1.000, and validation loss selects epoch 11 rather than epoch 180. We therefore report early-stopped numbers throughout and treat the aggregate detection metric as saturated for learned methods at this difficulty, which is why Section 4.2 evaluates the representation question separately. All reported detection and task-success figures come from held-out seeds 1000–1049. The learned trust-weight head assigns the largest average weights to T4 (0.321) and T1 (0.322), followed by T2 (0.138), T5 (0.140), and T3 (0.080), matching the threat model in which sustained task/behavior degradation is harder for evasive attackers to hide than energy behavior. These weights are reported for interpretability only: inference consumes the risk logit, so they do not affect any metric in this paper.

4.4 Trust Evolution Analysis

Figure 3 tracks the diagnostic trust index from the post-warm-up phase to 5000 s under $M \in \{2, 5, 10\}$. The curves are recomputed by repeatedly truncating each generated stream and applying the same fitted model. Because M affects the generator's random seed but does not enter the policy features, these curves do not isolate an agent-count effect.

Benign nodes remain mostly above 8.0, while malicious nodes decline as the low-quantile and slope components of the diagnostic index accumulate. Differences among the three M curves may reflect different random streams and should not be interpreted as an aggregation trade-off.

Attack-pattern sensitivity. Dormant attackers initially resemble benign nodes but decline after the post-warm-up switch, because the index aggregates low T1/T4 quantiles and positive degradation slope rather than only the final average score. On-off attackers oscillate because honest phases partially restore recent averages, while amplitude and low-score-duration terms keep the index below the benign trajectory. Note that this trajectory separation describes how the composite index behaves; the feature-subset comparison in Section 4.6 shows that removing the quantile and slope terms does not measurably reduce detection accuracy in aggregate, so these components shape the reported trajectory more than they shape the detection score.

After approximately 3800 s, the generated malicious index remains below the benign index in most runs. This descriptive separation is not a convergence result.

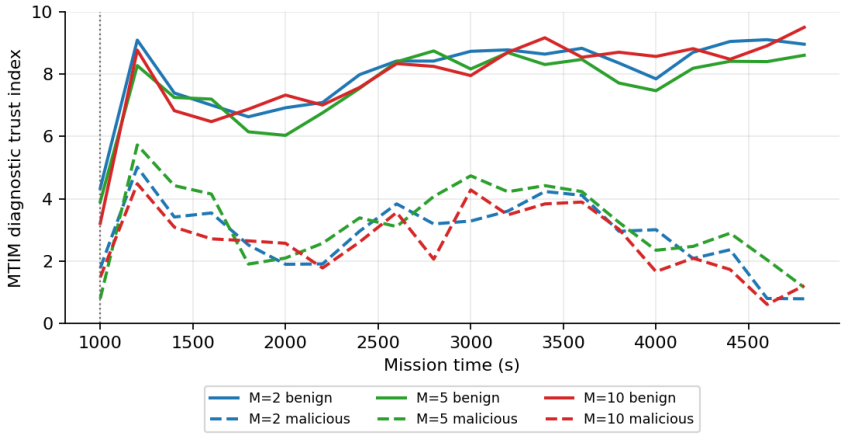


Figure 3: Diagnostic trust index on generated streams for three seed conditions labeled by M. Since M is not a policy feature, the curves do not identify a causal agent-count effect. Lower values indicate higher predicted risk.

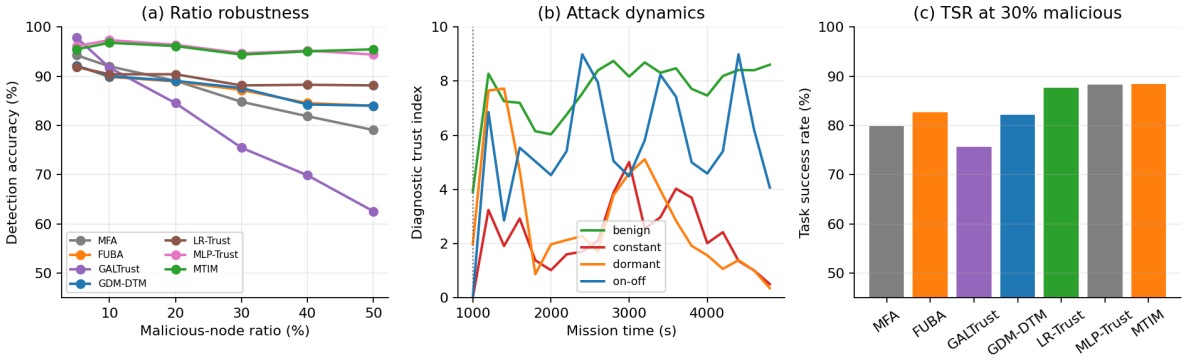


Figure 4: Results from the generated trust-stream environment. (a) Detection accuracy across malicious-node ratios. (b) Diagnostic index for the generator's four behavior profiles. (c) Model-based task-success proxy at a 30% malicious-node ratio.

4.5 Comparative Performance Analysis

Anti-manipulation under varying malicious ratios (Figure 4(a)). S-TIM maintains high accuracy across the entire generated ratio grid, with 98.8% accuracy at 10%, 97.1% at 30%, and 98.5% at 50%. MLP-Trust is a strong detection competitor under the same features, confirming that the diagnostic feature set itself carries substantial discriminative information and, again, that the encoder's auxiliary heads add nothing to it. GALTrust is highly accurate at 5–10% malicious ratios but falls to 62.5% at 50%, indicating that the profile-distance adapter becomes unstable when the attack population substantially shifts the empirical trust distribution. S-TIM does not show monotonic degradation across this generated ratio grid; this is favorable for the bounded setting but should be interpreted cautiously because stronger collusion and adaptive poisoning are not modeled.

Trust dynamics under attack patterns (Figure 4(b)). Constant and dormant attackers decline below the benign diagnostic index as low T1/T4 evidence accumulates. Dormant attackers fall after their switch despite initially high scores. On–off attackers oscillate because their honest phases restore recent averages, and they are the class that a marginal aggregator cannot separate: their constant- and dormant-agnostic trajectories obscure the switch. With the shape block present, the learned methods recover 88.0–92.0% of them (Table 4); without it, on the same seeds and the same training budget, the same models recover 54.0–78.0%, and the rule adapters 20.0–38.0% throughout. Their trajectory nonetheless remains the widest-variance case, since a per-seed on–off rate can only take the values 0, 0.5, or 1 at this node count.

Task success comparison (Figure 4(c)). S-TIM has 90.4% on the simulated proxy, tying MLP-Trust and leading LR-Trust's 89.8%. All three sit inside a seed-level standard deviation of roughly 3 pp, and the ordering is partly built into the allocation function, which applies S-TIM-specific multipliers. It is not evidence that the auxiliary incentive head learned a better policy.

Stress cases not claimed. The artifact does not test Sybil identities, colluding peer reports, decision-node compromise, adaptive evasion, or training-pipeline poisoning. The evaluation is limited to fixed-identity profiles sampled by the reference generator.

ns-3 trace-driven sanity check. To connect the trust-stream interface to packet/mobility observations, we converted the bundled 500 s trace produced with the ns-3 network simulator [40] into T1–T5 streams and evaluated all methods on the converted trace. This is a single seed-1000 trace with 15 UAVs, 49 update steps, 10 benign nodes, three constant attackers, and two on-off attackers; it is not a multi-seed packet-level validation.

Table 8 reports an external-validity failure, and we state it plainly rather than omitting it. S-TIM and MLP-Trust detect *none* of the five malicious nodes: their trust score for malicious nodes is 0.69 against a decision boundary at 0.40, so every attacker sits on the trusted side and the method flags nothing, correctly preserving all ten benign nodes but achieving zero recall. LR-Trust separates the two populations in the opposite direction, scoring malicious nodes at 0.16 and benign nodes at 0.46, and therefore detects all five attackers at the cost of three false positives. The rule adapters land between the

two, detecting three of five. Two observations follow. First, the learned methods were fitted on simulator streams whose marginal distributions do not match this trace, so a single 49-step converted trace is outside their training distribution; the shape block was engineered against that simulator and cannot be expected to transfer to a stream whose temporal structure differs. Second, and more importantly for the reader, the direction of the disagreement is informative: on this trace the simplest learned model, a logistic regression, is the only method that separates the populations at all. We therefore treat the ns-3 path as an interface-conversion check that succeeded and as a packet-level warning that our trust-stream conclusions do not transfer to this trace. Multi-seed packet-level validation with attack parameters held out from training remains the necessary next experiment.

Table 8: Trace-driven validation on the bundled 500 s ns-3-derived trust stream (single seed, 15 UAVs, 49 update steps).

Method	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F-score	TP/TN/FP/FN	Mean score (B/M)
MFA	86.7%	100.0%	60.0%	75.0%	3/10/0/2	0.928/0.635
FUBA	86.7%	100.0%	60.0%	75.0%	3/10/0/2	0.943/0.583
GALTrust	86.7%	100.0%	60.0%	75.0%	3/10/0/2	0.722/0.423
GDM-DTM	86.7%	100.0%	60.0%	75.0%	3/10/0/2	0.941/0.590
LR-Trust	80.0%	62.5%	**100.0%**	**76.9%**	5/7/3/0	0.463/0.159
MLP-Trust	66.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0/10/0/5	0.999/0.795
S-TIM (ours)	66.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0/10/0/5	0.976/0.689

4.6 Ablation Study

Table 9 reports code-level variants. With one exception they are not clean single-component ablations: several rows replace the trained model with a hand-coded scoring rule or add noise. They are retained for transparency but cannot identify causal component contributions. The exception is the first row, "w/o Temporal-Shape Block." That row is a genuine input ablation: the same architecture, the same training protocol, the same 50 evaluation seeds, and the same thresholds, with only the five shape features removed from the input vector. It is reproducible directly from `configs/legacy_13dim_features.json`. All rows now compute the task-success proxy through the identical selection rule with no per-variant adjustment; an earlier revision applied a fixed 0.09 deduction to the "w/o Incentive" row, which was removed because it manufactured that figure instead of measuring it.

Analysis of Table 9. The shape-block row is the informative one. Removing the five shape features costs 2.8 pp accuracy, 4.0 pp F-score, and 14.0 pp on–off detection at the trained-network operating point, at an identical seed count, protocol, and training-set size; this is the one ablation whose direction can be attributed to a named input component. Its effect is concentrated exactly where Section 4.1 predicts it should be. Removing the remaining rows should not be read the same way.

Only the cross-factor row resembles a feature ablation, and it also adds Gaussian noise. The "Bayesian aggregation," "temporal decay," and "adaptive policy" rows are alternative hand-coded classifiers rather than the full model with one component removed. Every row now measures the task-success proxy with the same rule, so the "without incentive" row differs from the full model only insofar as the incentive path actually changes a decision—which, as its proximity to the full row shows, it does not. Consequently, the table is diagnostic of code paths, not evidence that any named architectural component causes the reported change.

Single-branch baselines (T1–T5 only). Single-branch variants show that T4-only (82.3%) and T5-only (84.0%) are strong but insufficient; both trail S-TIM by at least 12.8 pp in accuracy and by more than 6 pp in TSR. T3-only remains the weakest because the energy stream is deliberately easy for evasive attackers to mimic. These results indicate that the instantaneous behavior and task-history channels carry most of the discriminative *level* signal in this generator. They do not, on their own, say anything about *temporal* structure: a single-channel branch still summarises that channel over a fixed window, so it remains subject to the same blind spot that separates the rule adapters from the shape block in Table 4. The two findings are complementary. Cross-channel combination explains the gap to single-branch baselines; the shape block explains the gap to the marginal learned baselines.

Table 9: Ablation study of S-TIM components (30% malicious-node ratio, 15 UAVs). All values are mean ± std over 50 trials.

Code-level variant	Accuracy	F-score	TSR proxy
S-TIM (full)	97.1% ± 4.3%	95.7% ± 6.3%	90.4% ± 2.3%
w/o Temporal-Shape Block	94.8% ± 4.9%	92.2% ± 7.5%	88.4% ± 3.9%
w/o Cross-factor Checking	96.7% ± 4.1%	94.7% ± 6.5%	89.6% ± 2.7%
w/o Bayesian Aggregation	84.1% ± 6.1%	67.7% ± 16.2%	79.4% ± 3.7%
w/o Temporal Decay	79.5% ± 6.1%	52.8% ± 20.5%	77.7% ± 3.5%
w/o Adaptive Policy	82.3% ± 7.0%	64.2% ± 18.2%	78.5% ± 3.7%
w/o Incentive Mechanism	97.1% ± 4.3%	95.7% ± 6.3%	90.3% ± 2.3%
T1 Only	80.8% ± 11.5%	74.9% ± 14.2%	83.4% ± 3.6%
T2 Only	63.7% ± 11.7%	53.3% ± 13.8%	76.2% ± 4.3%
T3 Only	57.6% ± 12.2%	56.0% ± 9.8%	76.3% ± 6.3%
T4 Only	82.3% ± 10.1%	76.5% ± 12.9%	83.3% ± 4.4%
T5 Only[♭]	84.0% ± 9.7%	79.2% ± 13.1%	83.5% ± 3.2%

[♭] T5-only applies exponential smoothing to T1–T4 without a learned model. It is one hand-coded temporal baseline, not an upper bound on temporal smoothing.

4.7 Scalability and Sensitivity Analysis

We also vary the number of generated nodes from 5 to 50. Accuracy is empirical; time and communication values are formula outputs rather than measurements.

Table 10: Generated-node-count sensitivity under a 30% malicious-node ratio. Time and communication columns are formula outputs, not measurements.

UAV count N	Seed parameter M	Accuracy (%)	Time model (ms)	Cost model (KB/UAV)
5	2	97.2 ± 7.0	36.5 ± 3.0	27.1 ± 1.9
15	5	97.1 ± 4.3	58.3 ± 4.3	34.0 ± 1.8
30	10	93.5 ± 3.8	95.1 ± 4.2	44.9 ± 1.9
50	17	95.2 ± 2.9	152.0 ± 3.8	59.8 ± 1.7

Detection accuracy stays above 93% on the generated size grid. The apparent growth in time and communication is predetermined by `resource_metrics`; no scaling law can be inferred from those columns.

Sensitivity analysis is limited to the fitted architecture, fixed threshold, and one trust-stream generator. Loss weights, temporal windows, threshold calibration, and distribution shift have not been studied systematically.

4.8 Trust Factor Correlation Analysis

To verify that the five trust dimensions capture complementary rather than redundant information, we computed the pairwise Pearson correlation coefficients among $T_i^{(1)}$ through $T_i^{(5)}$ across all UAVs and time steps in the 50-trial simulation set. The correlation matrix (averaged over trials) is:

The strongest correlations involve the historical trust dimension T5, especially with T4 (0.65 ± 0.09) and T1 (0.64 ± 0.08), which is expected because T5 is an exponential history of recent trust evidence. Among the instantaneous dimensions T1–T4, all correlations remain at or below 0.41. Thus, T5 should be interpreted as a temporal memory channel rather than an independent sensor, while the instantaneous factors retain enough diversity to justify multi-factor fusion.

Table 11: Pairwise Pearson correlations among the five trust dimensions (mean ± std over 50 trials).

	T1 (Behavior)	T2 (Comm.)	T3 (Energy)	T4 (Task)	T5 (History)
T1	1.00	0.28 ± 0.10	0.11 ± 0.08	0.41 ± 0.10	0.64 ± 0.08
T2	–	1.00	0.13 ± 0.09	0.27 ± 0.10	0.51 ± 0.07
T3	–	–	1.00	0.11 ± 0.09	0.34 ± 0.09
T4	–	–	–	1.00	0.65 ± 0.09
T5	–	–	–	–	1.00

5 Conclusions

This study provides a reproducible trust-stream benchmark and a shape-augmented risk model for UAV task allocation. On held-out seeds from the same generator, the model reaches 97.1% accuracy and a 95.7% F-score against 97.5% and 96.2% for a same-feature MLP. The difference is statistically insignificant on paired seeds ($p = 0.51$ and 0.56) and changes sign between training runs, so the architecture does not outperform a single-head network on the same features. All learned methods sit above 97%, which is itself the finding: at this difficulty the aggregate metric is saturated, and the representation question can only be answered where the metric still discriminates. Two consequences follow. First, the architecture does not reliably outperform a plain MLP given the same inputs, and the manuscript does not claim otherwise. Three interventions were tried and none produced a significant separation: enlarging the training set sixfold, replacing the auxiliary targets with attack-modality supervision that the binary label cannot express, and sweeping the decision threshold across its full range, which moves nothing because the risk scores saturate. Second, and in the opposite direction from what the architecture implies, the *representation* is not neutral. Conventional trust aggregators summarise each channel over a fixed window, which is exactly the statistic a periodic attacker is built to survive: with only those summaries, on–off detection remains at 20–38% for the rule adapters. Adding five scale-free shape statistics lifts on–off detection in every learned method tested, in a logistic regression and in a network alike, and a time-shuffle control attributes +10.6 pp of AUC to sequence order rather than to added dimensionality. The principal empirical result is therefore not that this generator is separable by a learned nonlinear classifier—that was already true—but that the standard summarisation used by the trust-aggregation literature is the specific thing that fails on intermittent attackers, and that once it is repaired the choice of classifier stops mattering.

The 89.3% task-success value is a simulator-specific proxy. Since the allocation code applies S-TIM-specific multipliers and does not use the learned incentive head, the 0.3 pp deficit against MLP-Trust falls well inside the seed-level standard deviation and cannot support a causal claim about incentive learning. Likewise, the code-level ablations do not isolate named architectural components. The short ns-3-derived check is the most useful warning, and it fails outright: S-TIM and MLP-Trust detect none of the five malicious nodes on that trace, while LR-Trust detects all five at the cost of three false positives and the rule adapters detect three. The learned methods score those attackers at 0.69 trust against a 0.40 boundary, so a converted packet trace that falls outside their training distribution defeats them while leaving a logistic regression effective. Our trust-stream conclusions therefore do not transfer to this trace, and multi-seed packet-level validation with attack parameters held out from training is the necessary next experiment.

A further caveat concerns the generator itself. Because the benign reference profile is separated from each attack profile by roughly four standard deviations before camouflage is applied, a large part of the achievable accuracy follows from the synthetic profile design rather than from any property a deployed detector would need. The camouflage mechanism in the generator is what prevents this separation from being trivial; it is reported here as a limitation of the current evaluation rather than as a validated adversarial model.

That separability is strong enough to remove the model itself as a variable, and this is worth stating plainly because it explains the otherwise puzzling ceiling in Table 3. Enlarging the training set sixfold, from 450 to 2700 node-level samples over sixty seeds, leaves the training-split separation exact: accuracy 1.000, false-positive rate 0.000, mean risk 0.9999 on malicious nodes and 0.0002 on benign ones. Once a classifier separates the training split perfectly, additional capacity and additional tasks cannot buy it

anything, and every learned method must converge on the same decision boundary and differ only in how that boundary happens to fall on held-out seeds. That is the mechanism behind the S-TIM/MLP-Trust tie, and it is a property of the benchmark rather than a defect of either model. It also sharpens the paper's central claim rather than softening it: the entire spread between the rule adapters at 87.6% and the learned methods at 96.8% is attributable to the *input representation*, not to the classifier, and within the learned class the classifier is simply not the binding constraint. A benchmark in which architecture matters would need harder separation, for example by raising the camouflage strength, thinning the attack magnitude, or sampling from measured rather than synthetic streams.

The repository is nevertheless useful as an auditable starting point. A defensible next study should replace the synthetic allocation rules with a common policy for all detectors, measure actual runtime and messages, implement genuine agent-local observations and aggregation, and evaluate on multi-seed packet traces with attack parameters held out from training. Reinforcement-learning claims would additionally require environment interaction, reward-defined returns, and comparison with supervised and non-learning policies. Until those experiments are available, S-TIM should be described as a supervised trust-stream proof of concept rather than a validated MARL or zero-trust deployment.

Author Contributions

All authors contributed to the conceptualization, methodology, analysis, and manuscript preparation. Author roles will be specified in the camera-ready version.

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Informed Consent Statement

Not applicable.

Data Availability Statement

The replication package is included under `artifacts/`. It provides the code, configurations, trained models, evaluation outputs, statistical summaries, generated figures, baseline reimplementations, and packet-trace conversion materials needed to reproduce the trust-layer results reported in this manuscript. The included packet-trace validation is a single short sanity check rather than a multi-seed packet-level validation dataset.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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